

General Education Reflection

Throughout my time at Iowa State, I have had the opportunity to take general education classes that do not necessarily pertain to my field of study. As a computer engineering student, my general education requirements were not something I initially looked forward to. Courses like Introduction to Western Civilization and World Religions were outside of my technical comfort zone, and I initially took them to just check off requirements. However, what I did not foresee was how these courses would change my perspective and provide a drastic change of pace to my otherwise very technical workload. Over my four years, I found myself taking about one general education elective per semester to balance my workload, and turned out to be a great decision. Sitting in lectures that had nothing to do with code or technical theory gave me the chance to slow down and change my perspective in a way that engineering courses could not.

Beyond the course material itself, one of the unexpected benefits of stepping outside of my engineering bubble was the people I was able to meet. Taking general education courses allowed me to meet people in different Liberal Arts and Sciences majors, most of whom had perspectives and college experiences that were vastly different from my own. Conversations before or during class revealed how differently people navigate their time at Iowa State. It reminded me that this university is much bigger and more diverse than my engineering classes might let on.

One course that stood out among my general education classes was World Religions, which I took in the spring semester of my junior year. In my life, I haven't been greatly connected with religion, especially those that are not my own. Going into this class, I assumed it would be focused on a handful of religions and dive into the religious text and beliefs. What I found, however, was that the course more importantly emphasized the diverse ways that billions of people across the world find meaning, community, and purpose in their lives. Learning the foundational beliefs and histories of religions such as Hinduism, Islam, Christianity, and several others, including ancient religions, gave me more exposure to people whose worldviews differ from my own. A course like this has such a stark contrast to the systems and logic taught in engineering courses and I found myself enjoying the course much more than I predicted I would.

Looking back, my general education courses were never the most difficult classes that tested my capabilities and work ethic, but they were unique and thought provoking classes that shaped the perspectives that I have today. As I finish my final semester and prepare to step into my career, I carry with me not only the technical expertise from my engineering courses, but also the experiences and broader worldview that I obtained from my general education courses at Iowa State.